Technology and the internet

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Living with machines: technology and everyday life (235 words)

Few forces have reshaped modern life as quickly as digital technology. Each year brings a new **breakthrough** and a new **gadget**, and last year's **cutting-edge** device quickly becomes **obsolete**. **Innovation** drives economies, yet it also widens the **digital divide** between those who can afford the latest tools and those who cannot.

Artificial intelligence now writes, translates and diagnoses, while **automation** is steadily replacing routine factory and office work. Optimists argue that machines free people for more creative tasks; sceptics fear mass unemployment. In daily life, the change is just as visible. Most apps are designed to be **user-friendly**, and it is easy to **download** a new one in seconds, but many of them are deliberately **addictive**, built to hold attention for as long as possible. Children, in particular, show a growing **dependence** on screens, and the **virtual** world sometimes feels more real to them than the physical one.

The price of this convenience is a loss of **privacy**. Every online search leaves a trace, and a single **data breach** can expose millions of customers. Governments defend **surveillance** as a tool against crime, while civil-rights groups **raise concerns about** its misuse. Heavy **bandwidth** demand, **cyberbullying** and the spread of **misinformation** add to the list of problems. Even so, technology lets people **interact** across continents as never before. The real question is not whether we **keep pace with** the machines, but whether we can **stay in control of** them.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
raise concerns about	express worry over
keep pace with	stay level with
stay in control of	continue to direct

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
digital divide	n	the gap between people with and without technology	*The digital divide leaves rural areas behind.*
artificial intelligence	n	computer systems that copy human thinking	*Artificial intelligence is changing many jobs.*
automation	n	using machines instead of workers	*Automation has reduced the need for factory staff.*

cyberbullying	n	bullying through the internet	*Cyberbullying affects the mental health of teenagers.*
privacy	n	freedom from being watched or disturbed	*Online privacy is a growing concern.*
addictive	adj	hard to stop using	*Social media can be highly addictive.*
innovation	n	a new idea or method	*Innovation drives economic growth.*
obsolete	adj	no longer used because something better exists	*Typewriters became obsolete in the 1990s.*
cutting-edge	adj	the most advanced	*The hospital uses cutting-edge equipment.*
user-friendly	adj	easy to use	*The app is simple and user-friendly.*
download	v	to copy files from the internet	*You can download the lesson for free.*
data breach	n	when private information is stolen	*A data breach exposed millions of customer records.*
surveillance	n	careful watching, often by the state	*Public surveillance cameras are now common.*
bandwidth	n	the amount of data a connection can carry	*Video calls need a lot of bandwidth.*
gadget	n	a small useful machine	*Teenagers often want the latest gadget.*
virtual	adj	existing on a computer, not in real life	*Virtual classrooms are common now.*
interact	v	to communicate with others	*Apps help people interact across the world.*
dependence	n	needing something too much	*Dependence on phones is increasing.*
breakthrough	n	an important discovery	*The breakthrough made the vaccine possible.*
misinformation	n	false information spread by mistake	*Misinformation spreads fast online.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
curriculum	n	the subjects taught in a school
literacy	n	the ability to read and write
tuition fees	n	money paid for teaching at a university
compulsory	adj	something you must do by law
vocational	adj	connected with a job or skill
distance learning	n	studying away from a school, usually online

academic achievement	n	success in studies
peer pressure	n	the influence of people your own age
rote learning	n	learning by repeating facts
critical thinking	n	judging ideas carefully

Practice: fill the gaps

bandwidth · data breach · digital divide · innovation · privacy · gadget · cutting-edge · user-friendly

1. Video calls need a lot of _____.
2. A _____ exposed millions of customer records.
3. The _____ leaves rural areas behind.
4. _____ drives economic growth.
5. Online _____ is a growing concern.
6. Teenagers often want the latest _____.
7. The hospital uses _____ equipment.
8. The app is simple and _____.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

smartphone (n): a mobile phone with computer functions
app (n): a program for a phone
algorithm (n): a set of rules a computer follows
software (n): computer programs
hardware (n): the physical parts of a computer
firewall (n): a program that blocks unsafe access
password (n): a secret word to enter an account
hacker (n): a person who breaks into computer systems
malware (n): software made to cause harm
encryption (n): turning data into a secret code
cloud storage (n): keeping files on remote servers
streaming (n): watching or listening online without downloading
social networking (n): using sites to connect with people
e-commerce (n): buying and selling online
wearable (adj): worn on the body, like a smartwatch
robot (n): a machine that can do tasks automatically
drone (n): a small flying vehicle without a pilot
3D printing (n): making objects layer by layer from a digital design
self-driving (adj): able to drive without a person
digital literacy (n): the ability to use technology well
screen time (n): time spent looking at a screen
connectivity (n): the ability to connect to a network
upgrade (v): to replace with a better version
state-of-the-art (adj): using the newest methods
tech-savvy (adj): good at using technology
online platform (n): a website offering services
telecommuting (n): working from home using technology
e-book (n): a book in digital form
search engine (n): a program for finding information online
digital footprint (n): the trail of data you leave online

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Some people believe technology makes life easier; others think it makes life more stressful. Discuss both views and give your opinion.
2. Children spend too much time on screens. What problems does this cause and what can be done?
3. Artificial intelligence will replace most human jobs. To what extent do you agree or disagree?
4. Do the advantages of social media outweigh its disadvantages?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Technology saves time: online banking and shopping take minutes instead of hours.
- **Against / bad:** Constant notifications create stress and make it harder to focus.
- **For / good:** Automation takes over dangerous and boring tasks, so workers can learn creative skills.
- **Against / bad:** Machines replace workers faster than they can retrain, leading to unemployment.
- **For / good:** Video calls let families and teams stay in touch across the world.
- **Against / bad:** Data breaches and online surveillance threaten privacy.

Speaking

Part 1

- How often do you use your phone?
- What technology do you use every day?
- Do you prefer reading books or reading on a screen?
- Is there any gadget you want to buy?
- How has technology changed your hometown?

Part 3

- Will robots do most jobs in the future?
- Does technology make people lonelier?
- Should children have a smartphone? At what age?
- How can governments protect people's privacy?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a piece of technology you use often. You should say: what it is, how long you have had it, what you use it for, and explain why it is important to you.

Answers

1. bandwidth (bandwidth)
2. data breach (data breach)
3. digital divide (digital divide)
4. Innovation (innovation)
5. privacy (privacy)
6. gadget (gadget)
7. cutting-edge (cutting-edge)
8. user-friendly (user-friendly)